

simply fly to their targets in daylight without fighter escorts and drop their bombs on designated spots. This fantasy cost hundreds of young men their lives. Losses rose to as high as 50 percent on a single mission. And even if the bombers reached their targets, they could not bomb accurately enough to hit them.

From the spring of 1940, the unsustainable losses in daylight operations led to a switch to night bombing, for which Bomber Command was even more ill-prepared. Britain's political leaders were still reluctant to envisage attacks on civilians, authorizing raids against targets such as synthetic oil plants and railroad yards. But an official survey carried out in 1941 estimated that, groping blindly through the darkness over enemy territory, only one bomber in three managed to drop its bombload within 5 miles (8km) of its target.

Civilian targets

Logically, Britain should probably have abandoned strategic bombing altogether, at least until it could develop a fighter with sufficient range to act as a bomber

SIR ARTHUR HARRIS

THE REPUTATION OF Air Chief Marshall Sir Arthur Harris (1892–1984), head of Bomber Command from 1942 to the end of the war in Europe, has become the subject of impassioned public controversy, yet among the men he led, respect for his leadership was almost universal.

Harris had been a pilot in the Royal Flying Corps during World War I. He understood and fought for things his airmen needed – for better aircraft and equipment, for proper pay and leave, and for official recognition of their efforts – even if he had no hesitation in sacrificing their lives by the thousand in pursuit of victory. Harris never wavered in his advocacy of the bombing of cities as a war-winning strategy. His stubborn refusal to disown the February 1945 bombing of Dresden when it had become politic to do so was a piece of plain honesty that cost him dearly. He was shunned by the British establishment at the end of the war and was subsequently vilified for having carried through a policy that, in the war years, had enjoyed widespread support.



MAN ON A MISSION

Harris was a blunt and aggressive man, often to the point of rudeness. The force of his personality was felt through Bomber Command, stiffening aircrews' resolve to keep going in the face of heavy losses.

escort. But at that stage in the war it constituted the only way the British had to carry out offensive action against Germany. Accepting that technical limitations made night attacks on any target smaller than a city futile, in February 1942 Bomber Command was directed to focus on “the morale of the enemy civil population and, in particular, of the industrial workers.” The “area bombing” of cities was what the bombers were capable of, so that was what they would do.

RAF bomber crews on the whole responded to the switch to bombing of civilians with dutiful indifference or outright enthusiasm. One airman recalled: “When we were briefed it was made clear that for the first time we were not attacking any military targets, but were bombing a town

indiscriminately. A great shout of excited agreement greeted the news as most aircrews had come from towns that had suffered heavily from German air attacks.” Perhaps more typical was the attitude described by Avro Lancaster pilot Jack Currie: “I think we felt that we were in one hell of a battle for survival, and that we had to do, without too many qualms, the duties for which we were selected and equipped.”

The adoption of area bombing coincided with the arrival of a new commander, Arthur Harris, who had total faith in the war-winning potential of the bombing of enemy civilians. He soon made his mark by organizing three headline-grabbing “thousand-bomber raids” on Germany in May and June 1942. Since Bomber Command



EVENING TAKEOFF

As the light fades, RAF Short Stirlings line up to take off for a night raid on Germany. Stirlings could not reach the altitude achieved by Handley Page Halifaxes and Avro Lancasters and were often hit by bombs dropped by higher flying colleagues.

CITY DESTRUCTION

Hamburg was one of the most heavily damaged German cities. Until very late in the war, however, Allied bombers only rarely managed to inflict devastation on this scale.

